

Carriages and class

The critique of railways as an instrument of control, built to ease the plunder of colonial rule, emerged during the national movement primarily through Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi's writings. His work, *Hind Swaraj*, which was published in 1910, denounces the state of the third class and dissects the imperialist agenda of the railways. Third-class carriages had wooden benches, lacked lavatories, and people were packed in like sardines, while first-class passengers, often European, travelled in plush comfort. All the benefits of the railways accruing to the natives were happy accidents, he believed, and wrote, "Good travels at a snail's pace – it can, therefore, have little to do with the railways."

As painted stations whistle by

Despite Gandhi's criticism, the railways entrenched themselves in the nationalist's narrative. After Independence in 1947, they became an intrinsic part of India's social and economic fabric. This found face and form in Indian writing, aptly reflected in Indian writer RK Narayan's seminal 1935 *Swami and Friends*.

"As I sat in a room nibbling at my pen and wondering what to write, Malgudi with its little railway station swam into view, all ready-made, with a character called Swaminathan running down the platform," Narayan writes in his memoir *My Days* (1974). The sleepy, fictional town of Malgudi with its "little railway station", though southern in tone and texture was a microcosm for all small towns across India, a small station breathing vitality into the town, which otherwise lay frozen within its cultural homogeneity. The railway station was the signifier of alien technology, a reminder of colonial rule, and the promise of modernity. "Trains stop at Malgudi, newcomers arrive and disrupt the dreamy contentment of Narayan's heroes. Without their intrusion the novels would have no plot, and, more than that, they would have no point," writes British academic Richard Cronin.

Small towns and trains play a significant role in Indian author Ruskin Bond's work as well. He draws perhaps from his childhood holidays spent at the railway bungalow of his Uncle Fred who was a station